Appendix: Shansabānī Religious and Historical Inscriptions in Afghanistan and Pakistan[1]

Introduction

This Appendix gathers the known Shansabānī-related epigraphy from modern Afghanistan and Pakistan. Religious inscriptions refer to Ḥadīth, Qur'anic verses, and doxologies; historical inscriptions contain names, titles, dates, and other historical data. Overall, the inscriptions gathered here date to the period of the Shansabānīs' initial emergence as politico-military elites in Afghanistan, specifically the three principal agnatic lineages based at Jam-Fīrūzkūh, Bamiyan, and eventually Ghazna spanning the third and fourth quarters of the twelfth century. The Ghazna Shansabānīs' rapid expansion into the lower Indus region – almost immediately after the conquest of the erstwhile Yamīnī capital in AH 569/1173 CE (see Chapter 5) – renders the inclusion of the more easterly epigraphic data extremely informative. The published sources for the inscriptions are listed in footnotes on each site, while their detailed discussion is to be found in the relevant chapters of this volume.

Virtually since the beginning of European compilations of Islamic epigraphy for scholarly purposes – for example, the *Répertoire Chronologique d'Épigraphie Arabe* (*RCEA*), initiated in 1931 at Cairo's Institut Français d'Archéologie Orientale – both religious and historical inscriptions have been published together. This approach has implied parity in the practices of documentation that are followed by the compilations, and has at least theoretically underscored the scholarly significance of both epigraphic genres.

However, this was in fact far from the case: as R. Hillenbrand[2] has pointed out specifically for the *RCEA*, historical inscriptions actually *determined* which religious inscriptions would be recorded, *viz.* only the religious texts preceding (very rarely following) historical ones were collected (cf. also Chapter 4 notes). Without direct access to the sites of study, investigators today would be largely working with only those inscriptions that the editors of the *RCEA* and other compilations deemed worthy of documentation. Fortunately, several scholarly works (books and articles) on epigraphy in various media – on architecture as well as portable objects – have emerged, particularly in the latter half of the twentieth century, to supersede such inherently biased methodologies.[3]